DHARMARAO BALAGA

Head of UX | Head of Product Design | Senior / Principal Product Designer

Hyderabad, India | +91 97044 32414 | dharmaraobalaga@gmail.com

linkedin.com/in/dharmarao-balaga-7a67937 | behance.net/dharmaportfolio | dharmaraobalaga.github.io/portfolio

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Senior product design leader with 20+ years of experience across mobile, gaming, SaaS and enterprise products, including 7 years as Head of Product Design at Openplay Technologies (Nazara Games). Combines product thinking, user-centered research, UX strategy and interaction design with hands-on craft in design systems and high-fidelity UI — and a foundation in animation, visual communication and storytelling from an M.Des at IIT Bombay.

Today, as Founder & Principal Product Designer of D'SARAS Design Studio, applies generative AI strategically across discovery, research synthesis, ideation, rapid prototyping and visual exploration — shortening the path from problem to validated design while keeping human judgment, usability and business goals at the centre.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Product & Strategy: Product Thinking · UX Strategy · Product Discovery · Problem Framing · Data-informed Design · Design Consulting

Research & UX: User Research · Usability Testing · Research Synthesis · User Journeys · Information Architecture · User Flows · Wireframing

Interaction & UI: Interaction Design · Rapid Prototyping · High-fidelity UI · Mobile & Responsive Design · Visual Design · Motion

Systems & Scale: Design Systems · Scalable Component Libraries · Design Tokens · Design Standards & Governance

Leadership: Design Team Leadership · Mentoring · Stakeholder Management · Cross-functional Collaboration (Product, Engineering, Marketing)

Domains: Mobile Gaming · SaaS & B2B · E-commerce · Enterprise Software · E-learning

AI & DESIGN TOOLS

Design & Prototyping: Figma · Figma AI / Figma Make · Google Stitch

Generative AI for UX: ChatGPT · Claude · Google Gemini — discovery, research synthesis, ideation, UX writing, prototyping

Generative Visual & Motion: Midjourney · Leonardo AI · Runway ML — visual exploration, concept art, motion studies

AI Experience Design: Human-centered AI patterns · Human-in-the-loop workflows · AI-assisted design productivity

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Founder & Principal Product Designer — Feb 2025 – Present

D'SARAS Design Studio, Hyderabad — AI-enabled design studio · dsaras.com

- **End-to-end product design consulting:** lead engagements for startups and businesses from discovery and problem framing through UX strategy, information architecture, interaction design, prototyping and high-fidelity UI.
- **AI-assisted design practice:** built a studio workflow that uses ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Figma Make and Google Stitch for research synthesis, ideation and rapid prototyping, significantly reducing design turnaround time.
- **Design systems:** created scalable design systems and component libraries, including the studio's own DSDS system with design tokens, wing-specific colour themes and responsive patterns.
- **OnlyTWAM:** delivered complete UX/UI for a premium women's essentials e-commerce mobile app — multi-screen UI and an interactive prototype built on a dedicated brand design system.
- **D'SARAS digital presence:** designed and built the studio's multi-section website (Design, Growth, Academy and Stories) as a responsive single-page application.
- **DesignAcharya (emerging initiative):** designing a 6-month UX/UI and Product Design programme with AI-era positioning, aimed at mother-tongue-first (Telugu–English) design education.

Head of Product Design — Jan 2018 – Jan 2025

Openplay Technologies (Nazara Games), Hyderabad

- **Design leadership:** owned product design strategy and execution across multiple gaming and digital product ecosystems for 7 years; built, managed and mentored a multidisciplinary design team.

- **Classic Rummy transformation:** led the redesign from a legacy Flash product to a modern native mobile experience — reimagining onboarding, navigation and gameplay flows with culturally relevant UI for Indian users, improving retention and engagement.
- **Design systems & standards:** partnered with Product, Engineering, Marketing and Leadership to establish design standards and scalable design systems for consistent delivery across products.
- **Data-informed decisions:** drove data-informed design decisions, using user research and product insights to prioritise improvements.
- **AI adoption:** introduced AI-assisted research and design workflows that raised team productivity.

Design Manager / Creative Head **Mar 2014 – Jan 2018**
Adeon Media Technologies, Hyderabad

- **UX & creative strategy:** led UX/UI and creative direction for enterprise and consumer web and mobile applications, including work for client brand Frodoe.
- **Team leadership:** managed multidisciplinary design teams across concept, UX and visual design.
- **Research-led delivery:** conducted user research and usability evaluations to deliver scalable, user-centred digital experiences.

Earlier Career — Illustrator → Graphic Designer → Animator → Team Lead **2001 – 2014**
Cordys Software · Esya Technologies · Helix Tech Solutions · The Boston Group · Polygon Studios · Globarena Technologies · Color Chips India

- Progressed from illustration to team leadership across software, e-learning, animation and visual-communication companies.
- Built deep foundations in branding, e-learning content, character and animation design, and visual storytelling that now strengthen product, motion and interaction work.

SELECTED PRODUCT DESIGN PROJECTS

Classic Rummy — Mobile Gaming *Openplay Technologies · Shipped product*

Migrated a legacy Flash card game to a native mobile experience. Redesigned onboarding, navigation and core gameplay flows with culturally relevant UI for Indian players, improving retention and engagement.

OnlyTWAM — AI-Augmented Mobile Product Design *D'SARAS Design Studio*

- Led end-to-end product design for a premium women's essentials e-commerce mobile experience.
- Used Claude for early concept exploration and Figma Make AI to develop the interactive mobile app prototype.
- Iteratively refined the experience through 135 saved Figma Make versions, applying designer-led evaluation and UX judgement.
- Explored privacy-first shopping, product discovery, fit assistance and streamlined checkout experiences.

ResolveAI — AI Customer Support SaaS *Self-initiated concept · Portfolio project*

Concept for an enterprise B2B support platform where AI assists and human agents stay in control. Covers ticket management, agent workflows, analytics dashboards and AI quality monitoring, with explicit human-in-the-loop decisions and trade-offs documented in a full case study.

D'SARAS Design Studio — Digital Presence · dsaras.com *Own studio*

Brand identity, design system (DSDS) and a responsive multi-section website presenting the studio's Design, Growth, Academy and Stories wings, with integrated portfolio and curriculum content.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- Led the Product Design function at Openplay Technologies (Nazara Games) for 7 years, building and mentoring a high-performing design team.
- Led a platform migration of Classic Rummy from Flash to native mobile, improving retention and engagement.
- Founded D'SARAS Design Studio and established AI-powered design workflows now used across client engagements.
- 20+ years of design experience spanning gaming, mobile, SaaS, e-commerce and enterprise products.

EDUCATION

Master of Design (M.Des) — Design, Animation & Film — *Indian Institute of Technology Bombay* **Jul 2010 – Jun 2012**

Bachelor of Fine Arts (BFA) — Applied Arts — *JNAFAU, Hyderabad* **Dec 1996 – Dec 2001**

LANGUAGES & AVAILABILITY

Languages: English, Telugu, Hindi

Open to: Senior / Principal Product Designer, AI Product Designer and Product Design Consultant roles — Hybrid, Onsite or Remote